

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Practice

Do It Before You Need It.

Reading gives you information. Safe, repeated practice shows whether your supplies, instructions, and skills actually work before stress, darkness, or disrupted utilities make every task harder.

PRACTICE TURNS KNOWLEDGE INTO ABILITY.

START TODAY

Run one small, safe drill

1

Choose one task with a clear objective, such as finding every flashlight or cooking one stored meal.

2

Gather the people and supplies involved. Explain what is simulated and what remains normal.

3

Do the task using only the equipment and written instructions you expect to have.

4

Record what worked, what failed, what was missing, and who will correct each gap.

STOP RULE

End the drill if conditions become unsafe. Never disable smoke or carbon-monoxide alarms, essential medical equipment, medication refrigeration, emergency communications, or necessary utilities

merely to make a drill feel realistic. Do not create real fire, electrical, structural, or sanitation hazards.

BUILD CONFIDENCE GRADUALLY

One skill, one objective, one improvement

You do not need a dramatic survival exercise. Begin with a short task that can be completed safely, then increase complexity only after the basics work.

Choose → Do → Observe → Improve

☐ **Choose:** Name exactly what you want to prove.

☐ **Do:** Use the real supplies, people, and written instructions.

☐ **Observe:** Note time, fuel, water, missing items, confusion, and safety concerns.

☐ **Improve:** Assign a person and date for every correction.

Practice the essential systems

WATER

Make safe water

Do: Find containers, clarify cloudy water if needed, use your planned treatment method, cool it safely, store it cleanly, and label it. **Record:** treatment time, fuel used, yield, and whether you could do it without grid power.

FOOD

Cook one outage meal

Do: Prepare familiar stored food without the electric stove, refrigerator, or a store trip. **Record:** water, fuel, preparation time, portions, satisfaction, and missing tools.

SPROUTING

Grow a small batch

Do: Sprout lentils or mung beans with clean equipment and safe water. **Record:** seed amount, rinsing schedule, days to harvest, water used, yield, smell, texture, and whether the batch remained clean.

SANITATION

Set up, but do not use

Do: Line the toilet or bucket with a strong bag, stage absorbent and paper, choose a protected waste location, and make a handwashing station. **Record:** setup time and missing hygiene supplies.

FIRE AND HEAT

Operate the approved system

Do: Outdoors or in an approved, properly vented installation, practice startup, control, shutdown, and boiling a large pot of water. **Check:** fuel, clearances, ventilation, alarms, and extinguisher. Never improvise indoor combustion.

TOOLS

Complete a small task

Do: Use a hand saw, hammer, shovel, adjustable wrench, or another expected tool for an ordinary task. **Record:** condition, sharpness, protective equipment, effort, maintenance needed, and storage location.

FIRST AID

COMMUNICATION

Open and use the kit

Do: Find gloves, gauze, bandages, tape, cold packs, and medicines; practice a simple bandage on an uninjured volunteer. **Check:** dates, medication lists, training, and the nearest AED. Use training equipment for advanced procedures.

Work without internet

Do: Turn off Wi-Fi on one device, find the radio, tune a known station, use a printed contact list, and review meeting places and the out-of-area contact. **Record:** battery condition and information missing from paper copies.

COMBINE THE BASICS

Try a short power-outage period

For a few planned hours, avoid nonessential conveniences such as main lights, the electric stove, television, and home internet. Keep essential systems available and tell everyone when the exercise starts and ends.

SEE

Use staged flashlights, headlamps, or lanterns and move safely.

EAT

Prepare one simple stored meal with the approved backup method.

COMMUNICATE

Use printed contacts, radio, and the household meeting plan.

CONSERVE

Track battery, fuel, and water use instead of guessing.

Keep it safe: Do not disconnect refrigerators holding essential medicines or food that cannot safely warm, medical devices, alarms, sump pumps, heating needed for life safety, or any system whose interruption could cause damage.

SHARE THE KNOWLEDGE

Practice with other people

One person should not be the only one who knows how to treat water, operate approved equipment, find supplies, shut off water, or contact help. Let each person perform an age- and ability-appropriate task while another person observes.

PRIMARY

Does the task

Uses the equipment and explains each step.

BACKUP

Repeats the task

Uses the written instructions and identifies unclear steps.

Run a five-minute after-action review

Worked

What should remain unchanged?

Didn't

What failed, confused people, or took too long?

Missing

What supply, skill, instruction, or backup was absent?

Owner

Who will correct each gap?

Due

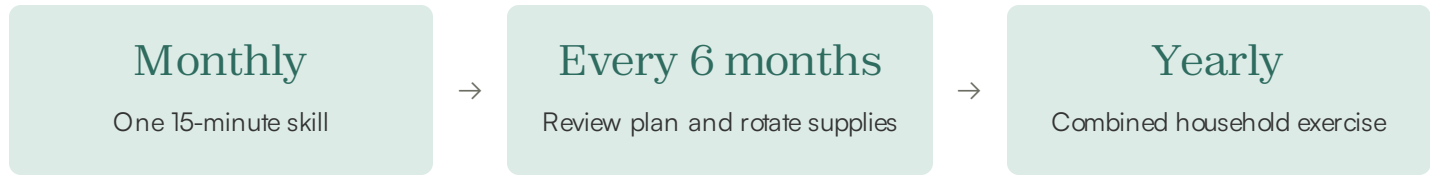
When will it be fixed and retested?

FINDING	CORRECTION	OWNER	DUE / RETEST

Write observations while they are fresh: dead batteries, missing wrench, excessive fuel use, unclear labels, difficult instructions, or food that required too much water.

MAKE PRACTICE ROUTINE

Use a simple repeating schedule



Also retest after moving, changing equipment, adding a household member or pet, developing a new medical need, or finding a problem during an actual outage.

SKILLS TO DEMONSTRATE

Simple practice list

☐ Purify or disinfect water correctly

☐ Boil water without grid power

☐ Cook one emergency meal

☐ Sprout a small batch of seed

☐ Set up an emergency toilet

☐ Create a handwashing station

☐ Operate an approved heat or cooking system

☐ Use basic hand tools safely

☐ Locate and use the first-aid kit

☐ Find emergency lights in the dark

☐ Charge an essential device

☐ Tune the emergency radio

☐ Locate water, electrical, and fuel shutoffs

☐ Practice the meeting and contact plan

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

- ✗ Buy equipment and never operate or maintain it.
- ✗ Store food you have never prepared with the backup method.
- ✗ Assume every household member knows the plan.
- ✗ Make the drill hazardous to make it feel realistic.
- ✗ Test too many systems at once before mastering the basics.
- ✗ Depend entirely on instructions stored online.
- ✗ Ignore accessibility, medical, child, elder, or pet needs.
- ✗ Notice a failure but never assign or verify the correction.
- ✗ Make practice so complicated that no one repeats it.

TRY THIS NOW

The one-hour challenge

Simulate loss of electricity and running water without actually disabling anything essential or unsafe.

1. Find working emergency lighting.
2. Find and measure available drinking water.
3. Identify the approved backup cooking method and fuel.
4. Set up the emergency toilet and handwashing station without using them.
5. Open the first-aid kit and locate bleeding-control supplies.
6. Find, power, and tune the radio.
7. Locate the most important hand tools and utility shutoffs.
8. Write down every missing, expired, unclear, or inaccessible item.

Choose the most important gap, correct it, and repeat that part of the drill.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have actually treated water with my planned method.

☐ I have cooked a meal with my approved backup system.

☐ I have successfully sprouted seed.

☐ I can set up emergency sanitation and handwashing.

☐ I have used and maintained my basic hand tools.

☐ I know what is in the first-aid kit and where it is.

☐ I have tested flashlights, radios, batteries, and charging options.

☐ I can locate important shutoffs without searching online.

☐ Other people know the plan and can perform essential tasks.

☐ We record, assign, correct, and retest problems found in practice.

REMEMBER

What you read can be forgotten.

What you practice becomes familiar.

What becomes familiar is easier to do under stress.

LEARN IT. DO IT. KNOW YOU CAN DO IT.

Official planning and practice resources

Use local emergency guidance and task-specific training when designing household or community exercises.

Ready.gov: Make a Household Plan(<https://www.ready.gov/plan>)

Ready.gov: Are You Ready? In-Depth Guide(<https://www.ready.gov/sites/default/files/2021-11/are-you-ready-guide.pdf>)

Ready.gov: Low and No Cost Preparedness(<https://www.ready.gov/low-and-no-cost>)

FEMA: Preparedness Activities and Webinars (<https://www.fema.gov/emergency-managers/individuals-communities/preparedness-activities-research-webinars>)
